
The U.S. Open Has Never Seen Anything Like That Alcaraz–Shelton Match. It Was Even More Surreal in Person.

Published by

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Estimated reading time

7 min

Added on

2026-09-10

Address

<https://slate.com/culture/2026/09/tennis-us-open-2026-alcaraz-shelton.html>

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A bit after 2 a.m. on Wednesday, Carlos Alcaraz [waved away ESPN's cameraman](#). It was an act of great consideration, because a few moments later the Spanish star appeared to [barf into his towel](#). “We still have a camera guy there,” ESPN’s James Blake noted unnecessarily as Alcaraz spewed. “This did not look great.”

Not long after that, Alcaraz’s opponent Ben Shelton headed to the bathroom, having stripped off his sweat-soaked sleeveless top. By the time the freshly clad Shelton returned to Arthur Ashe Stadium, a man wearing in-ear headphones was striding back and forth outside an elevated luxury suite, ignoring the action below as he [mopped the floor](#) from left to right—on the hunt, perhaps, for stray chunks from a very long day’s worth of spilled and/or expelled [\\$23 Honey Deuces](#).

This was the beginning of the fifth set of one of the most dramatic, and [far and away the latest-finishing](#), matches in U.S. Open history. It was also apparently the start of the overnight cleaning shift, a convergence that felt appropriate on a night when those of us who stuck it out until the end of four consecutive matches that all went to a final set—the second of those, Frances Tiafoe’s win over Alex Michelsen, ended with [Michelsen crying on Tiafoe’s shoulder](#)—got treated to a litany of scenes you don’t typically see at a Grand Slam tennis match.

Sports-wise, the most significant of those later-than-late-night moments came at 3:33 a.m., when the 23-year-old Shelton clinched an epic 6–7(5), 6–1, 6–3, 1–6, 7–6(10–7) quarterfinal victory, taking down the seven-time major winner Alcaraz. Next up for Shelton: Friday’s all-American semifinal with Tiafoe, with the winner of that match back on court on Sunday afternoon with a shot to become the first American man to win a major since Andy Roddick in 2003. But tennis is a journey, not a destination, especially when it’s past 2:30 and two of the world’s greatest athletes are bashing away at each other for our entertainment while the custodial staff is cleaning around everyone’s feet. Here’s what all that looked and sounded like from my perch high above the court.

2:37 a.m.: Shelton cranks a first serve at 140 miles per hour, a feat that’s totally normal for him—he’ll do it throughout the fifth set—but feels like it should be impossible given that it’s nearly an hour after 1:40.

2:39 a.m.: The in-stadium DJ, who I’m hoping negotiated some kind of overtime arrangement, sets an all-time Grand Slam record (presumably) by spinning DMX up in here, up in here, in the neighborhood of 3 a.m. Take that, All England Lawn Tennis & Croquet Club!

2:45 a.m.: At two games all in the fifth set, Alcaraz smacks a down-the-line forehand winner to earn a break point. Shelton saves it with an overhead smash that knocks Alcaraz on his ass, then wins the game 2 points later with yet another 140-mile-per-hour first serve. He nods his head and waggles his racket, then points to the ground—a “This is my house” gesture, I think, unless he’s pointing out a spot that needs mopping—as the crowd roars.

2:51 a.m.: This is now the latest match in the history of the U.S. Open, surpassing the 2:50 a.m. finish of the [2022 quarterfinal between Alcaraz and Jannik Sinner](#)—Alcaraz won in five sets over 5 hours and 15 minutes—that instigated the rivalry that’s defined men’s tennis ever since. This year, the “Sincaraz” matchup has mostly been on hold, with Alcaraz missing the French Open and Wimbledon with a balky wrist and Sinner now out with a knee injury. But on this night at least, “Bencaraz” feels like a more-than-acceptable substitute.

2:54 a.m.: At three games all, Shelton loses the first 2 points on his serve to go down 0–30. During the next point, he hits three straight inside-out lefty forehands, pushing Alcaraz outside the doubles alley and forcing an error. Shelton’s coach, his father Bryan, stands and applauds. Bryan Shelton is 60 years old and appears totally awake and engaged. He’s in the running for the best performance by a Shelton tonight.

2:57 a.m.: Shelton holds for 4–3 with a 144-mile-per-hour serve. A different custodian starts sweeping the suites with a broom. The first match in Wednesday’s day session begins in less than nine hours.

3:00 a.m.:

it’s 3 AM. Ben is shouting Vamos (as usual). Carlos is shouting Let’s Go. It’s all happening. Tennis. Drama.

— Ricky Dimon (@Dimonator)

[September 9, 2026](#)

3:02 a.m.: Shelton hits a backhand pass just out of Alcaraz’s reach—“one of the most important, best passing shots he’s hit ever,” says ESPN’s John McEnroe—to get 2 break points. If he wins either one, he serves for the match. Instead he loses them both, on a flubbed chip-and-charge and a popped-up volley. Shelton then gets a third break point and loses that one, too.

3:05 a.m.: Alcaraz holds for 4–4, then screams “Let’s go!,” naturally. The match is now four hours long. ESPN’s cameras show Kevin Hart, whose recent Netflix movie *72 Hours* has a run time of 1 hour and 45 minutes.

3:12 a.m.: With Shelton serving at five games all, Alcaraz gets wrong-footed and ends up attempting a [tweener](#) that doesn’t come anywhere close to working. This match is definitely drunk, and Alcaraz’s maneuver here strikes me as the tennis equivalent of eating a jumbo slice of pizza after a very long bar crawl. The man is not thinking all that clearly, but can you really blame him? This is his first tournament back after his wrist injury. He also just barfed, and none of us should be awake right now.

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3:16 a.m.: Shelton holds for 6–5. Our between-games entertainment is a dance remix of “[\(I've Had\) The Time of My Life](#)” from *Dirty Dancing*. The DJ is locked in.

3:20 a.m.: We're into [the match tiebreak](#), first to 10 wins. Shelton takes a 3–1 lead, then loses 4 points in a row, then wins 3 back to back to even things at 5–5.

3:30 a.m.: At 6–6, the crowd chants “Let's go Ben! Let's go Ben!” He responds with a 146-mile-per-hour serve to take a 7–6 lead. Then, as Alcaraz serves, there's a bunch of loud beeping from what sounds like a loading dock. One of the big storylines at this year's Open has been the supposed onslaught of [disruptive, ring light–deploying influencers](#). So then, a useful tip for TikTok and Instagram: Wait until 3:30 and you've got carte blanche to back up an enormous truck right in the heart of a fifth-set tiebreak.

3:33 a.m.: Up 8–7, Shelton gets a service winner and then an ace. It's all over. He sticks out his tongue, then embraces a smiling Alcaraz at the net. The world feed camera cuts to Shelton's sister, who looks at the sky and says, “Thank God.”

3:45 a.m.: Waiting in a corridor for the two players to come out and speak to the press, I hear a scream from somewhere behind the walls: It's Shelton, celebrating the biggest win of his career. When he strides into the hallway, a reporter asks him how he's feeling. [His answer](#): “I'm tired.”

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